



“...the world is changing faster than many of us would imagine.”

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slow to adapt to the new trends in communications technology.

Not for long, though—passing through Denver airport on a recent trip to the US, I was amazed to see that almost all boarding gates have now become wireless ‘hot spots’. Take out your computer, click your browser and you are on the Web faster than you can say ‘PDA’!

With the number of hot spots expected to soar from a few hundred in 2003 to over a hundred thousand by the end of the decade, and cellular providers such as Sprint and Verizon boosting the capabilities of their wide area networks to facilitate high speed data transfer, the world is changing faster than many of us would imagine.

Picture three scenarios so eloquently described in *Hemispheres Magazine* and you will get the message: Wireless Point of Sale devices are beginning to augment, and in some cases replace, the traditional billing stations at major retailers such as Home Depot, Sears and K-Mart, with agents walking up customer checkout lines armed with handheld PCs and order scanners—a process that is being referred to as line busting. Barton Marlow, a Michigan construction firm, is setting up wireless networks at all its construction sites to help engineers, financial analysts and other site and corporate office employees share architectural blueprints, project plans, spreadsheets and e-mails to speed up the construction process. And the third, Studio Pipelines of America, a Vancouver television production company, has given PDAs to all studio hands, producers and even actors on production sets, and connected them to a wireless network to enable set planning and even script updating to be done ‘on the fly’.

The Inevitability Of Technology-Led Transformation

Alvin Toffler once talked about people who “suffer from the dizzying disorientation caused by the premature arrival of the future,” and it is not surprising to find that the rapid changes that technology is causing in many lifestyles and workplaces often happens at a pace that staggers even the most techno-savvy of communities and even countries.

Nothing epitomises this more than the telecommunications industry in India. In a land where a famous Harvard professor once said “half the population was waiting for a telephone while the other half was waiting for a dial tone”, it is amusing, though not surprising, to find not just educated professionals but even farmers and milkmen making effective—and sometimes innovative—use of the mobile phone.

In fact, a few years ago, it seemed that the wireless revolution would catapult Asia ahead of the long-developed nations of the USA and the UK, where the traditional population were

What has been the sequence of events leading up to this movement of wireless technologies into the mainstream of business? The ill-fated Apple Newton, introduced in 1993, was probably the first attempt in this area, but it was the introduction of the Palm Pilot three years later that really set off the revolution in handheld computing.

And now, notebook computers with Intel’s Centrino technology come with inbuilt wireless capabilities; PDAs provide wireless connectivity through national and international carriers; smartphones and pocket PCs are beginning to merge in terms of features and functionalities; and tight integration between computing and communications is enabling seamless handling of voice, data e-mail and text messages, with multimedia messaging services now being provided as well.

The ubiquitous Bluetooth will soon make seamless and cordless communication between smart devices a feature of all working